

C O A G N E S
Structural Analysis

The Displaced Verb

*On the Grammar of Accountability
in the Age of Artificial Intelligence*

"AI will take your job" is not a forecast.

*It is a grammatical manoeuvre —
assigning the verb to the wrong noun.*

*This document does not argue for or against artificial intelligence. It examines the grammar by which
responsibility is transferred, and identifies the structural positions where human agency is quietly removed.*

I.

The Sentence

Consider the sentence:

"AI will replace millions of workers."

It is spoken daily — by journalists, executives, consultants, and politicians. It has the ring of prophecy. Yet it contains a precise structural deception.

Artificial intelligence does not employ anyone. It has no authority to dismiss. It signs no contracts. It holds no fiduciary duty. It cannot be named in an employment tribunal.

THE GRAMMATICAL OPERATION

The subject is displaced.

A decision made by a board, a chief executive, a shareholder resolution — is attributed to a technology. The verb "replace" migrates from human agent to inanimate tool.

The object is abstracted.

"Millions of workers" — not colleagues, not individuals with mortgages and children, not named persons. The abstraction permits emotional distance.

The tense is prophetic.

"Will replace" — future tense removes present accountability. No one is responsible for what has not yet happened, even as the decisions enabling it are taken today.

The technology becomes a screen upon which human decisions are projected as if they were natural forces.

II.

The Cascade

Behind every redundancy attributed to artificial intelligence, there is a chain of human decisions. Each link in the chain is individually rational. Taken together, they produce a system in which people may be optimised out of existence — not by machines, but by other people, acting through machines.

THE CHAIN OF AGENCY

1 The Shareholder Mandate

Returns must increase. Cost must decrease. This is not optional — it is the fiduciary grammar of the corporation. AI enters the sentence here: as a tool that promises to fulfil this grammar more efficiently.



2 The Executive Decision

A named individual — a chief executive, a managing director — signs the restructuring order. The decision is human. The authority is human. The accountability, in law, is human.



3 The Operational Layer

Departments are reorganised. Roles are redefined around automated processes. The language shifts from "dismissal" to "transformation." The affected individuals become "legacy headcount."



4 The Displacement

Former employees enter a labour market that has been structurally narrowed by the same optimisation logic. Their skills, built over decades, are reclassified as redundant.



5 The Second Optimisation

Those who fall through — into debt, into housing precarity, into the margins — encounter a welfare system itself under optimisation pressure. The system that produced their displacement now classifies them as inefficiency.

At no point in this chain does artificial intelligence make a decision.

At every point, a human being does.

III.

The Recursive Trap

There is a structural recursion at work. The same optimisation logic that displaces individuals from employment is subsequently applied to the systems meant to support them. Housing assistance is measured by throughput. Mental health services are assessed by unit cost. The rhetoric that accompanies this — "the system should not support those who won't help themselves" — performs the same grammatical operation identified in Section I.

Once more, the verb is displaced. "Won't help themselves" attributes agency to the person least equipped to exercise it, and removes it from the institutions whose structural function is precisely to provide that help.

THE GRAMMAR OF EXCLUSION

Optimise

People are removed from employment in pursuit of efficiency.



Displace

The displaced are reclassified as a systemic burden.



Exclude

Support systems are optimised to reduce the burden — by reducing the support.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a grammar — a set of structural habits by which accountability is distributed away from those who hold power and towards those who bear its consequences. Artificial intelligence accelerates the process, but it does not author it.

*The question is not whether AI is dangerous.
The question is who decides what it is used for,
and who bears the cost of that decision.*

IV.

The Matrix

A clear delineation of what AI systems may risk, and what remains — structurally and legally — the province of human decision.

DOMAIN	AI RISK ZONE	HUMAN RESPONSIBILITY
Employment Decisions	Automates tasks, identifies "efficiency" patterns, models cost reduction	Decides who is made redundant, signs dismissal, owes duty of care
Structural Displacement	Amplifies speed of labour market contraction; narrows re-entry pathways	Designs retraining policy; allocates transition funding; regulates market impact
Welfare & Support	May be used to triage, classify, or score individuals seeking assistance	Sets eligibility criteria; ensures due process; preserves human appeal
Public Discourse	Generates and amplifies narrative framing; normalises dehumanisation	Editorial accountability; platform governance; regulatory oversight
Accountability Architecture	Creates complexity that obscures causal chains; diffuses attribution	Maintains transparent decision records; ensures auditability and redress
Data & Privacy	Processes personal data at scale; profiles behaviour; enables surveillance	Determines data policy; enforces GDPR; ensures consent and proportionality

The Questions That Remain

If a technology cannot sign a contract of employment, how can it bear responsibility for ending one?

If optimisation is the stated purpose, and human displacement is the observed outcome — at what point does the purpose become the outcome?

If the rhetoric of "AI replacement" serves to diffuse accountability across an impersonal system — whose interests does that diffusion protect?

If the displaced become a cost to be further optimised, and the optimisation itself displaces further — who is responsible for interrupting the recursion?

If we accept the grammar of the displaced verb — "AI will take your job" —

**we have already consented
to the disappearance of the person who gave the order.**

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